2. THE PREHISTORY OF THE PERMANENT WAR ECONOMY

In history, the great moment
is when the savage is just ceasing to be the savage.
Ralph Waldo Emerson, "Power"

Blood Meridian, published in 1985, is Cormac McCarthy's first novel set in the Southwest. While the subsequent volumes that make up *The Border Trilogy* are concerned with the period from the 1930s to the present, *Blood Meridian* is temporally located in the 1840s, in the years following the Mexican War and the Treaty of Guadalupe-Hidalgo that ceded much of what had been northern Mexico to the United States. Along with the Gadsden Purchase (signed 1853, ratified 1854), American victory against Mexico served to consolidate the continental national body articulated by the expansionist ideology of Manifest Destiny and the Monroe Doctrine. With the demarcation of an international borderline across the two thousand miles from the Pacific to the Gulf of Mexico, the United States for the first time achieved a national definition of unbroken continental totality.

McCarthy's novel, then, is quite clearly located during a decisive moment in the process of national identity formation, the moment when the desert lands of Sonora are incorporated into what has become the American Southwest. If *The Border Trilogy* will focus on the dispossession of Anglo ranching culture by the oil industry and the military-industrial complex, *Blood Meridian* is grounded in a concern with the consequences of possession. The novel is certainly unequivocal in its assessment of the nature of this acquisition: it is unrepentantly violent and chaotic, ruthlessly opportunistic, and driven by the necessarily unchecked libidinal forces of a rampant primal individualism tacitly legitimated by the absent presence of Anglo capitalist democracy.[1]

The importance of *Blood Meridian* for this study lies precisely in its construction of a kind of prehistory of the American Southwest. The novel is highly sensitive to the peculiarities of time and space as they are understood in the desert West and how spatiotemporal measurement is imbricated in modes of representation bound up with national ideology. Set as

it is when the meaning of a specific territory is transformed by a change of ownership, *Blood Meridian* is concerned in part with how space is formed into landscape, how anterior readings of that space become overwritten in the process of acquisition, and how this overwriting enables and perpetuates forms of representation that lay waste to the referent and all possible counterreadings. In other words, the novel is concerned with the establishment and maintenance of a sovereign discourse. Such a discourse is inseparable in the novel from a particular conception of war.

As I suggested in the previous chapter, among the promises of the modern nation-state is the externalization of war beyond its boundaries. But if Foucault and others are right that this promise merely represses the fact of war's continuation by other means, the establishment of the state's boundary—and the cessation of war this boundary serves to mark—is, in fact, the point at which the repression of war's continuation takes place. In recent times, as Hardt and Negri assert, "we seem to have been catapulted back in time into the nightmare of perpetual and indeterminate war."[2] Our "postmodern state of war," they claim, "resembles the premodern wars."[3] Published during Reagan's campaign of low-intensity conflict in Latin America and revival of apocalyptic Cold War rhetoric, *Blood Meridian* is a response, I intend to argue here, to the moment when the desire to overcome the "Vietnam Syndrome" that afflicted Civil Rights era military-industrial legitimacy is achieved through a neoconservative, neoliberal catapult back in time whereby the externalization of war promised by the nation-state is disavowed in favor of war's permanent state of emergency. As such, *Blood Meridian*'s tendency to move between the historically specific and the indeterminately prehistoric works to expose the contemporaneity of the prehistoric as a mode of temporal distancing that is, in fact, strategically useful in maintaining the open secret of permanent war.

In a way, *Blood Meridian* is a kind of creation story: it marks the moment when chaos becomes form, if we consider, from the viewpoint of the expansionist, the Southwest to be meaningless before it is given shape by occupation. In this view, the agents of Manifest Destiny call place into being, at the same time violently removing contradictory signs of prior habitation; space is made void in order for its re-presentation as place to occur.[4] The notion that the novel may be concerned with the production

of order and meaning from a site imagined as feral and vacant goes some way to explaining the curious temporal fluidity of the text, which, while being rooted in verifiable historical time, as I have said, also plunges into geological deep time in a way that moves the book far beyond the precincts of any conventional historical novel.

Blood Meridian is rightly celebrated for its descriptions of landscape, which produce a space that is both precise in its geophysical and climatological particularity and irreducibly strange and otherworldly. Barrenness has never required such detail. The lengths to which McCarthy goes in the construction of the desert borderlands serve, I think, to foreground the immense importance of modes of landscape representation as integral to the understanding of the site's function in the national imaginary. For the representation of landscape in *Blood Meridian*, in its particular and otherworldly doubleness, suggests ways in which history is both revealed and concealed simultaneously through the articulation of space. In the first place, as geographically remote from centers of U.S. power, the border territories are literally far from view, enabling the brutal process of conquest to continue out of sight and providing the distance that marauders like Holden and Glanton need in order to claim authority for their deeds that cannot be verified by the institutions of law they notionally serve. Whether or not U.S. authorities sanction the actions of filibusterers and scalp hunters is simply irrelevant since the end result—the clearing of the land for Anglo occupation—erases the means by which the end is achieved. More than the simple fact of remoteness from authority, however, it is the representation of the landscape as already wasteland that fully enables the completion of the process of conquest. As such, representations of the border landscape conspire to screen off alternative readings of desert space as anything other than dehistoricized, prehistoric, primal, and "naturally" empty: "[t]hey rode through regions of particolored stone upthrust in ragged kerfs and shelves of traprock reared in faults and anticlines curved back upon themselves and broken off like stumps of great stone treeboles and stones the lightning had clove open, seeps exploding in steam in some old storm. They rode past trapdykes of brown rock running down the narrow chines of the ridges and onto the plain like the ruins of old walls, such auguries everywhere of the hand of man before man was or any living thing."[5]

The precision of terms in a passage like this—"traprock," "anticlines," "chines"—draws from the language of geology and geomorphology and combines with a vocabulary of age—"some old storm," "the ruins of old walls"—to produce a terrain that is both eminently describable yet somehow beyond human comprehension. The readable signs "of the hand of man before man was" cements the paradox of marks made before mark-making, a kind of impossible history of inscrutable ruins. What agency there is here is primordial and requires unusual words like "kerf " (a cut or stroke) to register its remoteness. The chines and ridges are only "like" old walls, and the trace of occupancy is a chimera produced by a simile that invokes only to deny prior habitation. One might pass through such a place, but no one, it seems, has ever lived there.

While *Blood Meridian* is carefully researched and draws on a range of historical sources, stylistically it withdraws from any form of conventional historical realism.[6] Instead, the text appears to be hurled outside measurable human history and into a form of epic or cosmic spatiotemporal realm. This is the view of the novel put forward by Dana Phillips, who argues that "the American West in McCarthy's fiction is not the New World but a very old world, the reality of which is bedrock." As such, we might place him, Phillips goes on, "as a writer not of the 'modern' or 'postmodern' eras but of the Holocene, with a strong historical interest in the late Pleistocene and even earlier epochs."[7] Thomas Pughe makes a similar point when he claims that McCarthy presents us with "a history of the earth into which human history is sucked."[8] It is this prehistoric sensibility that links McCarthy to the epic, for the lack of interiority that characterizes epic narrative is similar, according to Phillips, to the descriptive practices of the earth sciences. By this he means the strategies of description that seek to depict the stuff of the world that exists prior and indifferent to, and also independent from, human agency. It is *Blood Meridian*'s "adherence in its descriptions of events to the protocols and paradigms of natural history that gives it epic resonance. The present world as McCarthy describes it is an ancient world not of myth but of rock and stone and those life forms that can endure the daily cataclysms of heat and cold and hunger, that can weather the everyday round of random, chaotic violence."[9]

Phillips is right, I think, to argue that McCarthy's understanding of Western history is natural history, one of forces and processes only barely adequately comprehended by human understanding. Certainly, McCarthy responds to the West with a sensitivity to geological duration and terrestrial violence that would not be out of step with someone like the geological catastrophist Clarence King. And as *The Border Trilogy* makes clear, this fascination with the extrahistorical and nonhuman extends to the feral world of animals, notably wolves and horses. In *Blood Meridian* the human protagonists, not to mention the countless unnamed Mexicans and Indians, are similarly rendered so as to evacuate all but the barest libidinal drives, leveling human intentionality to little more than the instinctual impulses of beasts.

The problem with this reading is that it does not take into account the historical specificity of the novel's events and the deliberate appropriation of historical figures like Glanton and Holden. As Richard Godden and Colin Richmond argue, citing Captain White's flagrant argument for an imperial policy of extermination and terror in Sonora, "[o]n such evidence it would be a mistake to read *Blood Meridian* simply as a baroque exercise, anymore than it is adequate to read *Moby Dick* (1851) as a romance."[10] The fictional space of *Blood Meridian* is indeed an ancient world of forces and processes, but it is also, at the same time, an inescapably particular historical space. Alongside the primal forces work historical forces, and McCarthy presses hard together the deep temporal dimension with the historically verifiable to produce a kind of fold in time whereby the prehistoric and the late 1840s appear to exist in the same place. Holden, Glanton, and others are both historically identifiable figures and also prehistoric, "of an order imperative and remote" (BM 152). Sometimes the dating of events is excessively precise, such as the scalp hunters' arrival in Ures on "the second of December of eighteen forty-nine" (BM 199), while often the men are described as stone age with nothing about them "to suggest even the discovery of the wheel" (BM 232). More than once they are figured as evolutionarily regressive, sitting "among the rocks without fire or bread or camaraderie any more than a band of apes" (BM 148), and are indistinguishable from "the rawest savage of that land" (BM 120). Spatially, of course, this effect can be produced through the setting of the geologically exposed Southwest, a

place where the ground is a persistent reminder of its long duration. But *Blood Meridian* does more than just imply that this is an ancient place upon which history occurs. The bleeding of prehistory into history produces human life forms that are themselves "[l]ike beings provoked out of the absolute rock . . . mute Gorgons shambling the brutal wastes of Gondwanaland in a time before nomenclature was and each was all" (BM 172). These are not, to be precise, actually creatures provoked out of rock but "like" such beings. The extended simile, while appearing to pull the text back into prehistory, reminds us that there is a critical difference between wandering across Gondwanaland and the Mexican desert of the 1840s. The power of the prose is such that metaphors and similes in McCarthy are easily read as straight description. While, as Phillips maintains, McCarthy's drive toward a disembodied depiction of the natural world bespeaks a determination to move through subjectivism toward the absolute rock of things as they are, the strategy produces more metaphorical slippage than documentary observation.

One result of this is to imbue the historical content—filibustering and scalp hunting in the wake of an imperial war of conquest—with an almost inconceivable temporal depth. On one hand, the 1840s is made to feel far away, while on the other, the eons of geological time are telescoped into the recent past. Another consequence of this telescoping of time is to alienate American history from any discernible connection with the present; the past here is not so much another country as another world. At the same time, it is also clear that it is the representation of Southwestern space itself, its geology, landforms, and climate, that facilitates this apparent annihilation of history, demanding that we take full account of the nonhuman environment in order to properly understand the site of human activity. The land, thus, is inseparable from the creatures and the deeds they perform upon it. Physical space is not the setting for but *is* history inasmuch as the life-forms, human and nonhuman, that occupy this space are of the same nature, made of the same stuff. McCarthy's strategy in folding history into the prehistoric reveals a powerful sense of environmental contingency, and in combining the epic resonance of the geological record with the specificity of the historical record, the prose demonstrates the fusion of geography and history, space

and time, necessary to properly articulate the appropriation of space into the national imaginary.

In this way, I think, McCarthy's text pulls in two directions at once. Pushing the 1840s into prehistory moves the acquisition of the Southwest so far back in time that there is no perceptible thread of connection between the process of conquest and the present. Confusing and complicating temporal causality in this way produces a sense in which the barbarism of the novel's protagonists can be read as "natural" rather than cultural, taking place in a time outside connection with the affairs of human civilization. As Phillips notes, *Blood Meridian* "treats darkness, violence, sudden death, and all other calamities as natural occurrences."[11] This reading suggests a conservative undertow to McCarthy's text as it erases the link between imperial wars of the past and the subsequent history of the United States: what happened in the past is long gone. Such a reading situates *Blood Meridian* among the classic literary and cinematic Western texts, where an unremarked upon gap separates the violence of domination that "broke" the land and its people and the moment of production and reception of the text that represents that past from a point of achieved domestication. The temporal arc of this narrative locates the beginning of history with the suppression of resistance; all that came before—"wilderness," "savages," wild animals—must therefore be "primitive" or prehistoric. This reading is enabled and reinforced through *Blood Meridian*'s utilization of many stock Western tropes: the alienated kid falling in with bad men, the corrupt soldiers, the ex-priest, the desert battles, the power-hungry charismatic leader, the unregulated economy of violence, and so on. The epic resonance of the text that Phillips locates in natural history is, furthermore, a masterly prose rendering of the classic Hollywood Western's choice of location.

It is appropriate to be suspicious of McCarthy's production of an arcane West as an effect that distances the text from complicity with the political and racist justification of imperial violence. But I do not think this is the only direction the text leads us. There are other implications behind McCarthy's use of geography to collapse history. For in some respects, the text deliberately makes visible the way the representation of space—such as descriptions of landforms and biota, the sensory effects of light and temperature, and the phenomenological and cognitive

experience of distance—produces temporal confusion and dislocation. In particular, the trope of the desert as external to human culture, a notional neutrality outside the affairs of history, is presented in *Blood Meridian* as precisely the place where U.S. history comes into being. Even the conservative reading of the West as wasteland to be redeemed follows this line of argument, but McCarthy, I believe, pushes this conception of "empty" space until it cracks. For the desert serves a double function in western culture; it is both the space of apocalypse and the site of an arduous revelation. The place that most completely blanks history might, then, also be the site where history is most glaringly revealed. While *Blood Meridian* on the one hand leads us toward an atemporal, inaccessible prehistory, on the other we are persistently reminded of the historical locatability of the events depicted. The novel exposes how a vocabulary of vacancy and always already wastedness is put to service in the erasure of temporal connections between violent conquest and its retelling as creation myth. The novel, however, is not explicit about this and indeed confounds all attempts to resolve or synthesize its temporal disjunctions.

The doubleness of McCarthy's text has been a subject of analysis for critics since Vereen Bell's early study noted that *Blood Meridian*'s many similes produce a divided "double image."[12] The identification of bifurcating trajectories in the novel does not mean, however, that there is any kind of straightforward dialectical relationship between them. Indeed, as I am suggesting with relation to the temporal fissure that opens up between prehistorical and historical time in *Blood Meridian*, contradictions generated by the text tend to be preserved and held in tension for the duration rather than resolved. One effect of this stasis is to reinforce the sense of unchanging, intractable inertia in the text to the extent that the reader soon abandons expectations of plot and character development. It is more than tempting at this point to position the novel as a deliberately negative critique of the attributes it patently does not provide. Susan Kollin, for example, points out that "[u]nlike the classic Western, *Blood Meridian* does not offer a region whose promise and possibility were somehow lost at a certain point in history, but a West fully corrupted from the moment Anglos arrived."[13] It is true that there is nothing "lost" in the West of *Blood Meridian*—unlike the novels of the *Border Trilogy*, the earlier work is not even interested in thinking through the ramifications of an

imagined organic relationship with history—but construing the novel as an "anti-Western" as Kollin does tends to preserve and merely invert the moral aspect of the genre the book purportedly operates within. As such, *Blood Meridian* can be made to function fairly straightforwardly as a negative critique of the "myth" of the West.[14]

This, I think, would be a mistake, and a number of critics of the novel have identified the difficulty of generating an oppositional position from the text. Kollin herself acknowledges that, just as classic Westerns have been said to be "divided texts," so too "anti-Westerns . . . are often unable to escape the very thing they seek to dismantle but instead are drawn into an intimacy and affiliation that destabilizes the critical effort."[15] Others have noted the "inert" (Peter Josyph) or "stalled" (Steven Shaviro) dialectic in *Blood Meridian*.[16] As Shaviro explains, there is no transcendence in *Blood Meridian*, and McCarthy refuses both the "rational mastery" of the Enlightenment and romantic "apocalyptic transfiguration."[17] What is revealed instead is the "ironic dependence" of the dream of transcendence "upon the very (supposed) mysteries that it claims to violate."[18] The result, as David Holloway proposes, appears to be a form of "willful self-cancellation, a writing from which any claim to determinate meaning or hermeneutic engagement with the world has been willfully expunged."[19] If the text's contradictions have rendered any possibility of resolution or direction impossible then it would be more accurate, Holloway argues, to refer not to the novel's contradictions but to its antinomies.[20] Frederic Jameson explains that a contradiction "is susceptible of a solution or a resolution" while an antinomy "states two propositions that are radically, indeed absolutely, incompatible," where "contraries are unable to enter into antagonistic contact and therefore develop themselves."[21]

This appears to be where we are with regard to *Blood Meridian*'s temporal doubleness: it is prehistorically indeterminate and historically specific both at once. The former distances events by pushing them to the horizon of deep time (primordial, geological, and biological), while the latter pulls the action up close and imbricates mid-nineteenth-century nation-building—once history is admitted—within an ongoing process that includes American imperial enterprise since 1848, including Vietnam and the Central American adventures of the Reagan years.[22] What is suggestive about both of these temporalities is not just that one seems to cancel

out the other but, more strikingly, that they both tend to represent a repetition of the same. *Blood Meridian*'s epigraph from the *Yuma Daily Sun* that reports the discovery of a scalped three-hundred-thousand-year-old skull signals at the outset that the novel will have little to say about historical change. Rather, the *longue durée* here seems merely to strengthen the implausibility of an historical alternative to wars of conquest. Gondwanaland becomes an echo of "the ashes of Gnadenhutten," from where the generations who "learnt war from warring" pour forth to the "bloodlands of the west" (BM 138) and on to the charred wastelands of North Vietnam and the jungles of Central America. Here *Blood Meridian*'s spatiotemporal confusions add up, since, as Godden and Richmond observe, "East meets West if viewed from the perspective of imperial ambition."[23] Again, folding history into prehistory appears to serve political realism's acceptance of human conflict as somehow "natural" and beyond the reach of liberal mediation. But this is to convert an antinomy back into a contradiction, and *Blood Meridian* will not quite allow that to happen.

Holloway argues that *Blood Meridian*'s antinomies should properly be seen as "historical symptoms" produced by a "world context where contradiction of a very worldly kind does indeed appear primordial and monolithic: a world where history itself, as a narrative movement through and beyond existing social contradiction, has become almost unthinkable."[24] When Godden and Richmond locate in Phillips's and Pughe's readings of the novel a disavowal of history in favor of geology, they are right to insist that McCarthy's "geological dimension does not decline from the human."[25] Instead, they argue that McCarthy's geology "most typically involves that which will become sand, grit or dust, each speck or grain of which has been, or will be, stained with blood." These are "the bedrock of McCarthy's terrain" and "are human in so far as they are monuments to killings, past, present and future."[26]

McCarthy's descriptions of landscape work inside a tradition of writing about the southwestern deserts that is nothing if not historical in its reliance on a particular combination of positivist scientific ambition and nationalist mystification. For John C. Van Dyke, whose *The Desert* (1901) has become a classic of Western nature writing, to enter the desert is to step back in time and feel the thrill of possession "by right of original exploration and conquest." In the desert, life "begins all over again, starting at

the primitive stage. There is a reversion to the savage."[27] The savagery is immanent in Van Dyke's landscape, the sun, wind, and sand themselves fiercely aggressive and annihilating: "[t]he sunshafts are falling in aburning shower upon rock and dune, the winds blowing with the breath of far-off fires are withering the bushes and the grasses, the sands drifting higher and higher are burying the trees and reaching up as though they would overwhelm the mountains, the cloud-bursts are rushing down the mountain's side and through the torn arroyos as though they would wash the earth into the sea."[28]

Life in the desert is also "peculiarly savage," with a "show of teeth in bush and beast and reptile" and everywhere "the presence of the barb and thorn, the jaw and paw, the beak and talon, the sting and the poison thereof." Here everything is "at war with its neighbor, and the conflict is unceasing."[29] McCarthy borrows this kind of rhetoric of perpetual struggle and natural aggression to good effect—the novel is full of snub-nosed descriptions of things like "deadlylooking bayonet plants," "shrubs blasted under the sun," and "deathcamas hanging in a small and perilous garden" (BM 57)—but, as Godden and Richmond suggest, this is not to say that the ahistoricizing tendencies of the natural scientist are to be taken at face value.

The events narrated in *Blood Meridian* take place around the time when the notion of the "prehistoric" was emerging as a category in the developing modern discipline of archaeology.[30] Closely aligned with Lyellian and Darwinian natural science as well as, later, the Spencerian notion of evolutionary progress that marks Van Dyke's feral vision of the desert, American archaeology configured all of pre-Columbian America as prehistoric.[31] One consequence of this thinking, of course, is that it compresses deep time and configures contemporary indigenous populations as living fossils. In the desert West not only does the landscape appear to be primordial but the human inhabitants are made to confirm this impression.

As a means of systematizing the strewn and buried debris of the past, archaeology provided a means of assembling order from pre-textual chaos. Alice Beck Kehoe sees American archaeology as a mode of "post hoc justification of the doctrine of Manifest Destiny," a bourgeois science that legitimated capitalist domination.[32] It did this by providing empirical evidence

that supported the notion of human progress "crowned by the Western nations' awesome machines."[33] Pre-Columbian civilizations could be factored into this argument through the countervailing notion of degeneration, which helped explain why nineteenth-century Indians seemed to have regressed from the achievements of the Aztecs and Anasazis.[34] Judge Holden is patently abreast of developments in archaeology, as his mania for cataloging artifacts suggests. And while he may be an agent of manifest destiny he does not necessarily subscribe to the ideology of progress. In the Anasazi ruins he sees a "judgment on the latter races" and, in a clear articulation of degenerescence, notes that "progressions from a higher to a lower order are marked by ruins and mystery and a residue of nameless rage" (BM 146). What McCarthy allows the judge to say here is that a geology of dust is indeed, as Godden and Richmond contend, made of the remains of the dead whose "spirit is entombed in the stone" (BM 146). McCarthy's description of the desert borderlands is as much archaeological as it is geological and is therefore historical inasmuch as it refers to the deeds of human beings. This is a qualified historical record, however, for it remains extratextual and thus, according to the archaeological rubric, is prehistoric and requires natural scientific articulation. This may be where history folds into geology and where time folds into space: if the traces of historical conflict—and here we must include the violent conquest of the Sonoran borderlands and the post–Pearl Harbor militarization of Western space, as well as its global extensions—are literally ground into the dirt, proof of their existence lies not in the pages of any historical account but in the rocks themselves. Taking this to be the case, it could be argued that McCarthy's description of geophysical and climatological conditions is indeed a mode of history inasmuch as the desert surface is the site upon which history is graven.

In *Blood Meridian* there does appear to be something of a conspiracy between the killers and the land when it comes to the destruction of evidence, and here the active erasure of the trace of violent deeds colludes with the construction of desert space as already empty. The scalp hunters actually aid in the production and preservation of empty desert by actively clearing the land of inhabitants, who are either killed or flee. Even Glanton is surprised at the efficiency with which "nineteen men had evacuated

an area of ten thousand square miles of every living human" (BM 148). Equally, the desert makes its contribution to the voiding of evidence of mass killing. After the Tigua massacre, we are told that within days the blood of the dead "would crack and break and drift away so that in the circuit of few suns all trace of the destruction of these people would be erased. The desert wind would salt their ruins and there would be nothing, no ghost nor scribe, to tell to a pilgrim in his passing how it was that people had lived in this place and in this place died" (BM 174).

The desert is littered with the brittle remnants of departed communities; as Godden and Richmond observe, McCarthy's Southwest "is a cemetery."[35] What is striking about the different kinds of remains is that they soon become historically indeterminate. Godden and Richmond describe the Sonoran landscape as at once "conspicuously genocidal" and "spectacularly . . . monumental," suggesting that "[i]t takes time for acts of genocide to be turned into monuments."[36] On the evidence, though, it does not appear to take much time, though the monuments may be modest in the extreme. The fact is, descriptions of vacated or destroyed settlements are more or less the same whether the site is a recently abandoned Apache village (BM 148–49), an ancient Anasazi site (BM 139), or a still used cemetery (BM 175).

Geology must be seen, in the light of *Blood Meridian*'s scalp hunters' murderous granulation of any evidence of prior occupation, as empirical evidence of those events even as they are converted from history into landscape. They make history disappear through the annihilation of all evidence, relying on its inevitable ossification into geology.[37] This landscape—embodied history rendered invisible *as* history—subsequently acts as the open secret of American conquest. The antinomies of geology and history, prehistory and history, space and time are, as Holloway puts it, historical symptoms in a world where movement "through and beyond existing social contradiction has become almost unthinkable." McCarthy's antinomies may result in a stalled dialectic, but the text's lack of movement must stand as a function of what we might call the negative unconcealment of history. In other words, the screening off of the facts of conquest by landscape is as much as can properly be shown without returning to a metaphysics of transcendent revelation the text simply is not willing or able to perform.

Pandemonium of the Sun

Blood Meridian's creation story of U.S. continental consolidation is also at the same time a tale that marks the end of that consolidation, and here the function of the novel's description of geological, meteorological, and astronomical conditions is not to remove the narrative from history but precisely to scrutinize it. As I have suggested, the question of what time it is in *Blood Meridian* is confusing, and the novel appears to slip its temporal moorings and drift back across the millennia. However, there is surely no better way of telling the time than to follow the sun, and it is the novel's heliocentrism, with the sun as source of illumination and thus of visibility, that properly reveals *Blood Meridian*'s spatiotemporal concerns.[38] The sun offers a model for timekeeping that relies on cosmic movement rather than chronological measurement and tends to reinforce the sense that events in the novel do not advance but repeat and return. At the same time, though, the sun's movement can be reckoned from a human vantage point, enabling the conversion of cosmic movement into segmented chronological units of duration: dawn, meridian, evening. The sun is the source of enlightenment and offers a means of regulating the temporal dimension of the objects it makes visible, but in the inevitability of its glare the solar presence is also a sign of the repetition of the same.

For Georges Bataille, the supreme power attributed to the sun lies in the fact that, in the figure of noon, it represents "the most *elevated* conception." At the same time, the sun is also "the most abstract object, since it is impossible to look at it fixedly at that time of day." The power of the sun, then, lies in its "poetic meaning of mathematical serenity and spiritual elevation." Yet these values can only be bestowed upon the sun so long as it is not seen directly; serenity and elevation are appreciated only by indirection, through reflection. To look directly at the sun is an act of "certain madness" that yields not illumination but "refuse and combustion." The sun not looked at is beautiful, the one gazed at is "horribly ugly." Bataille's implication is that the authority of the sun as an elevated symbol of power is only made possible by a willful blindness that prefers the abstract indirectness of concepts to direct experience; indeed, to remain sane one must look away. The fact that the sun has been mythologically expressed "by a man slashing his own throat, as well as by an

anthropomorphic being *deprived of a head*" (emphasis in original) suggests an awareness of the catastrophic consequences of peering directly at the source of power. "All this leads one to say," Bataille concludes, "that the summit of elevation is in practice confused with a sudden fall of unheard-of violence," a fact he illustrates with reference to the myth of Icarus, which splits the sun into two: the inviting glow that beckons Icarus's ascent, and the one that melts the wax when he gets too close.[39]

The doubleness of McCarthy's novel begins with the title, which apparently offers a choice: *Blood Meridian, or, The Evening Redness in the West*. This choice bespeaks, I think, the text's forking political pathways. The dominant image is clearly that of the bloody sun, yet are we to read this bloodiness as the sign of the meridian, of the highest point in the sun's altitude, or of sunset, where the day ends? Temporally, it is not clear whether the text is positioned at midday or sunset, highpoint or lowpoint. In *Blood Meridian* there is more than an echo of "high noon," the point of reckoning, of purgative violence, while the *Evening Redness in the West* signals a waning, an ending. The "or" of the title seems to invite interchangeability and mark a point of uncertainty. The title could be a question or simply an offering of equivalences. That "or" as choice and uncertainty presents an ambiguity that haunts the novel.[40] The Treaty of Guadalupe-Hidalgo could be read as the ultimate line of partition that finally fences off the United States as an achieved historical totality, the meridian of Manifest Destiny after which the heroic phase of nation-building is over and now there must be only decline. Alternatively, this moment could signify the nadir of imperial barbarism, the historical moment where, thankfully, the sun is now setting. Perhaps the consolidation of empire is the beginning of the end.[41]

This doubleness is glossed at least once in the narrative, where we are told that while the "way of the world is to bloom and to flower and to die," for men "there is no waning and the noon of his expression signals the onset of night. His spirit is exhausted at the peak of his achievement. His meridian is at once his darkening and the evening of his day" (BM 146–47). The sense here is that the pinnacle of human expression signals an imminent decline, just as noon suggests the highest and hottest the sun is going to get. Every noon is thus latent with darkness; in one is written the other. Temporal unfolding is countered here with simultaneity,

the movement of human history being no more than an illusion of natural progression from bloom to flower to death. The "affairs of men" appear to be divorced from cosmic time, doomed to spiritual exhaustion, the blaze of achievement promising no radiant afternoon glow but simply the "onset of night."

A bloody sun is precisely what Bataille knows we will see if we look upon it: an authority that shines benignly in our thoughts but which cannot be looked at directly without the danger that we will see too much, that the horrors of that power will pour into our eyes and reveal the rottenness at the core of its celestial sovereignty. For Bataille, the sun is the logos, the principle of earthly power and mastery. It is the sign of the father, the glaring phallus of domination. McCarthy's travelers similarly labor under a sun that can cast runs of color "like blood seeping up" and which rises "at the edge of creation . . . like the head of a great red phallus until it cleared the unseen rim and sat squat and pulsing and malevolent behind them" (BM 44–45). As well as bloody, in the morning the sun can be "urinecolored" (BM 47); it is "remorseless" (BM 243), a "distant pandemonium" (BM 185); it "lay in a holocaust" (BM 105).

There is something fraudulent about the glow from sources of light, or at least about the truth claims made in the name of illumination, in the literal sense that what we see when we look at objects is not their materiality but the effects of light cast upon them.[42] In *Blood Meridian*, that which enlightens does not truly reveal but merely casts a light upon things. This should not be taken as an unveiling but as simply another form of distortion, a "will to deceive that is in things luminous" that may "post men to fraudulent destinies" (BM 120). Distortion of the past by false light, it seems, can send us off in the wrong direction.

The other way in which the sun's action upon the desert deceives is through the production of mirages. For the majority of the novel, McCarthy's wanderers barely seem to register the look of the landscape they traverse. But there is a point after the Comanche massacre of White's filibusterers where the kid and Sproule, after a typically punishing spell in the desert, appear to come across a lake and a distant city. As the sun falls, the lake and city "dissolve," and when they wake the next morning they find "only a barren dusty plain" (BM 62).

The sun as power, then, is duplicitous. The deceptiveness of luminous things, and the fact that the source of illumination can only be perceived indirectly, suggest that the source of power can only be intuited, never actually seen. What knowledge we have is obtained always already mediated through indirection, reflection, or "in retrospect," after the fact. If McCarthy favors the "absolute rock" of experience, the corrosive power of violent history, then the novel must court madness by looking into the sun.

The overwriting of American Manifest Destiny on the Southwest inscribes the narrative of acquisition on a land where for millennia the sun has expended its energy without recompense. The moment of McCarthy's narrative marks the point where a space of libidinal expenditure is converted into a place of production, where violence yields scalps and gold as forms of wealth to be accumulated rather than released back into the solar energy flows.[43] On the pivot of this turn into history stands Judge Holden, who represents both the acme of Enlightenment rational domination of the life-world and the ultimate warrior king. The judge straddles both worlds, and like his literary precursors from Natty Bumppo to Ahab, he must facilitate the safe arrival of the rational management of nature through his very acts of metaphysical violence. Claiming that "[w]hatever in creation exists without my knowledge exists without my consent," the judge speaks fulsomely for the totalizing power of encyclopedic knowledge (BM 198). He will document and destroy in order to convert material into fact. Yet later he will speak of war not as the instrument of domination but as a noble dance that has become dishonored (BM 331). The judge is both warrior and imperial functionary, spokesman of, in turn, expenditure and accumulation: "[e]very child knows that play is nobler than work"; "[w]ar is the ultimate game" (BM 249). He would restore the bloody nobility of sacrifice yet will also absorb the world into himself as property. While keeping notes on geology, fauna, and fossils, the judge can also observe that "[b]ooks lie" and that the truth is "in stones and trees, the bones of things" (BM 116).

In making this distinction the judge appears to prefer the empirical world before him, trusting the apparently unmediated truth of appearances. Yet those appearances are revealed only due to the light cast by the power of the sun. To look at stones and trees is not really to see them but

to see the temperatures of the objects as their brute matter is animated by the heat of solar light. The notional directness of vision required by the Enlightenment scientist is not direct at all but mediated by that object—the sun—that can only be known through indirection.

The sun is nowhere more powerful than in the desert, where the ferocity of the unsheltered gaze pitilessly illuminates the world of things. Stripped of defining shadow under the meridian sun the terrain becomes a "neuter austerity," and distinctions between objects appear to have been removed, "bequeathed a strange equality" (BM 247). The "very clarity" of things "belied their familiarity, for the eye predicates the whole on some feature or part and here was nothing more luminous than another and nothing more enshadowed and in the optical democracy of such landscapes all preference is made whimsical and a man and a rock become endowed with unguessed kinships" (BM 247). Critics have identified this celebrated passage as a form of metacommentary on the "horizontal" way in which the novel itself refuses to make distinctions between classes of objects (rocks and men, men and animals) or between kinds of activity (riding, eating, killing).[44] As such, landscape is not a background or stage upon which human agency is played out. Instead, natural forces and human actions are equally represented as both violent and motiveless.

This assessment of *Blood Meridian*'s style is consonant with the argument put forward here in that it confirms the way in which McCarthy's precision of description actually blurs rather than defines the place and time of the narrative. What I would stress about McCarthy's "optical democracy" is that the passage is about the perception of objects rather than about the material fact of the objects' existence. This is a passage about phenomenology rather than epistemology. We are warned that clarity does not mean that we know more about things; indeed, familiarity is given the lie by clarity, and what equality the lack of shadow bequeaths is "strange." What the direct light of the sun actually produces is an uncanny effect whereby familiar objects are made to appear otherwise. Indeed, what the desert sun illuminates is not the world of things but the contingency of vision, since the kind of light cast upon things changes the sense of what those things are and what they mean. There is an argument here, I think, about exposure and concealment, with "optical democracy" functioning as a sort of ideological special effect. The

unforgiving illumination of an all-pervasive light might be described as power (the sun, the state) showing itself, revealing its capacity for unifying its subjects (revealing the "unguessed kinships" between discrete entities). In this way, total illumination functions as a trope for total transparency and a promise of unambiguous correspondence between what is shown and what is seen (what you see is what you get). We might conclude, then, that the sun as provider of an "optical democracy" works to produce a plane of vision where everything appears to be revealed in its actuality and where each thing seems to be the kin of everything else. The sun's bald illumination creates an apparent totality where everything is connected, unambiguous, and shown as it really is: a state of nature uncomplicated by the shadows of cultural or political doubt. But as I have already said, this apparent clarity is strange, the complexity of things rendered overly simple by excessive illumination. The passage registers a skepticism toward the noonday sun that ought to be identified as a nascent form of critique.

If one of the things *Blood Meridian* manages to do is fold American history into natural history in order to interrogate the implications of naturalizing a process of imperial conquest, the maintenance of an optical (perceived) democracy based on illumination invites an analogy between cosmic power (the sun) and historical power (the state). One of the planks of liberal democracy is that its institutions operate according to the will of the people. Transparency of government is a precondition for the legitimacy of power since the exercise of that power is accountable to its source, the electorate. What the emergence of the national security state in the wake of Pearl Harbor inaugurated, as I argued in the previous chapter, was the seemingly paradoxical notion of secrecy and dissemblance as a necessary device for the protection of democracy, effacing transparency as a virtue. The Vietnam War and Nixon's adventures in Cambodia, not to mention Watergate, temporarily unraveled the justification for legitimate secrecy in pursuit of national security. The disillusionment with the institutions of government during the 1960s and 1970s indicates that in part the tacit Cold War acceptance of the hiddenness of power had been at best a mistake. What *Blood Meridian* suggests is that transparency produces what can only be a *perceived* and "strange" equality. To mistake this strangeness for clarity is to invest too heavily in the value of notionally

empirical evidence and the facts before one's eyes. It is to privilege the source of illumination over the thing illuminated and to mistake the glow of direct penetrating (as illumination is often described) light as enlightenment. As Bataille makes clear, we cannot look directly at the source of power but can only perceive its effects. And what we learn when we look at its effects is that we can never look directly at the source. In other words, what is really powerful about power is the way it conceals itself through the act of revelation. To look directly at the clarity of the articles illuminated makes them strange rather than familiar, and suggests that what we are seeing is not the truth about things "as they are" but only as they have been made to appear to be. "Optical democracy" is a good term because it qualifies democracy as an effect. The sun of McCarthy's title is the sun as power, conceived at its zenith (casting no shadow) and at its lowest (too much shadow). Just as this doubleness in the title means we cannot know what time of day it is (or where in time we are), only what color it is, neither can we be comfortable with whether what the novel shows us in its horizontality is the truth about power and history or only an effect of that power and that history. Nor should we be comfortable. This may be the limit of what McCarthy's book can do as "revisionist" history since the very idea of a revisionist reading infers that something can now be revealed which was once hidden. If my understanding of McCarthy's notion of optical democracy—and *Blood Meridian*—is right, any historical "truth" the novel may be imparting in its description of the bloody pursuit of America's Manifest Destiny (Sonoran and Saigon versions) can only be read by looking awry.

As I have suggested in my reading of McCarthy's representation of landscape, the novel demonstrates how agency can be effaced by the recoding of historical space as prehistoric. A similar action is performed, I think, through the judge's rhetoric of ritual and sacrifice as mystifications of war's political economy. The judge's view of war as a noble game with no end outside itself situates him within an economy of expenditure with links to the notion of sacrifice. For Bataille, sacrifice is put forward as a critique of production that gives back a noninstrumental meaning to objects that have been reduced to inanimate things by the productive world. The freedom offered here "is given in destruction," claims Bataille, "whose essence is to consume *profitlessly* whatever might remain

in the profession of useful works. Sacrifice destroys that which it consecrates."[45]

In this view, the warrior stands outside the world of productive labor and in contradiction to it. Discussing war and sacrifice in ancient Mexico, Bataille quotes the missionary and compiler of the Florentine Codex Bernadino de Sahagún:

> [The midwife would say to the newborn boy:] I cut your navel in the middle of your body. Know and understand that the house in which you are born is not your dwelling. . . . It is your cradle, the place where you lay your head. . . . Your true land is elsewhere; you are promised for other places. You belong to the countryside where battles are fought; you were sent to go there; your function and your skill is warfare; your duty is to give the sun the blood of your enemies to drink and to supply the earth with the bodies of your enemies to eat. As for your native land, your legacy and your happiness, you will find them in the house of the sun in the sky.[46]

This passage bears comparison with the opening description of the kid in *Blood Meridian*, who is also born into a house that is not his dwelling: "[h]e can neither read nor write and in him broods already a taste for mindless violence" (BM 3). At fourteen, the kid runs away to where battles are fought, to the house of the sun in the sky. The judge's grievance against the kid at the end of the novel is that he has turned away from his birthright as warrior: "[i]f war is not holy man is nothing but antic clay" (BM 307). Later, the judge continues his accusation that the kid has dishonored the warrior caste by not following his destiny. The true warrior is he "who has offered up himself entire to the blood of war, who has been to the floor of the pit and seen horror in the round and learned at last that it speaks to his innermost heart" (BM 331).

As Bataille's use of Sahagún suggests, linking the birthright of a warrior with a land of war fuses identity to place as part of an organic ritual of violence between the sun as power and earth as site. In Sahagún's account, warfare is sanctioned as the noninstrumental fulfillment of libidinal destiny. Jay Ellis's point that the meridian of McCarthy's novel is the line between untrammeled bloodletting and a more constrained and institutionalized violence is right, I think, and the judge's castigation of the kid is part of the former's awareness of the bureaucratic foreclosure of

war's ecstatic dimension as the nation becomes fenced in, with the kid's reticence, if that is what it is, as a sign of the kind of internalization of social norms that makes the pursuit of sacred violence untenable.[47] Once violence becomes instrumental it is no longer natural but merely functional and the legitimizing force of war-as-sacrifice hard to maintain. The judge must kill the kid in order to erase this evidence of compromised holiness, but it is a final purgative gesture that cannot restore the primordial state of war the judge has been instrumental in dismantling. Any remnant of the warrior's sacred function left in the aftermath of the externalization of war by the demarcation of the limits of the nation-state serves only as a legitimation effect for continued bloodshed.

A Geopolitics of Primordial Return

The parable-like epilogue to *Blood Meridian* appears to imply, as some critics have suggested, the imposition of mathematical regulation onto the nonhuman order of the Southwestern landscape. It is by no means clear what the epilogue is about, and the critical discussion has not been conclusive.[48] What is clear is that the insertion of an epilogue provides a narrative space outside of what Holloway calls judge Holden's "totalizing energy."[49]

In the epilogue, a man "progresses" over the plain by means of the postholes he is digging, one after the other. Space is being produced in accordance with the progression of incremental measure. The wanderers behind him mechanistically either search or do not search for bones, as if they are part of some kind of clock. Again, this appears to be the spatialized movement of temporal measurement. The wanderers cross the track of holes one by one, the track itself seeming to be "the verification of a principle, a validation of sequence and causality" (BM 337). Each hole verifies all the others, owes its existence to the principle of sequence rather than to its physical existence. Nothing is categorically demonstrated here, no real key to events is given: everything "appears," "seems," is "as if " there is meaning. However, it is hard to avoid the conclusion, as Phillips accepts, that this is a description of a more modern world than that of the 1840s, the time during which *Blood Meridian* is set, and that the world of the epilogue is one "in which the western plains have been rationalized—settled, fenced, and punctured."[50]

In a sense, the epilogue could be said to function as a bridge between the feral world of the 1840s and the heavily managed space of the twentieth century McCarthy goes on to explore in *The Border Trilogy*. The epilogue is a bewilderingly obscure but necessary device that demands we read the novel back through this final puzzle. It insists we understand the world of the novel as anterior to the act of measurement, before postholes and the very idea of sequence and causality. The posthole digger, then, serves to represent the construction of history: the delineation and regulation of time and space by the imposition of abstract systems of measurement. The epilogue, as Ellis argues, "demands both a mythic, and a historical, interpretation," since it calls forth a consideration of the broad symbolic and historically particular forces within which the novel's actions are situated.[51]

If Holden carries the double burden of Enlightenment rationalism and fallen warrior priest, this cocktail of logic and mysticism provides a vivid emblem of the military-industrial sensibility as it became manifest in the United States during the mid-twentieth century. The thorough domination of the Western lands could only be achieved through such a doubleness: brutal force and painstaking classification together ensnare the world of things and put them to use by using them up. While *The Border Trilogy* marks off the dispossession of the remnants of an older order, there is no aspect of that process that is not already at work in the years following the Mexican War.

The "chief Western preoccupation of the national government during the era of Manifest Destiny," claims William Goetzmann, "was a grand national reconnaissance of the entire trans-Mississippi country." The expeditions conducted by the Corps of Topographical Engineers, supervised by the Topographical Bureau, itself under advisement from scientific societies, were ordered to examine the plants, animals, Indians, and geological formations of the country they crossed. The plan was to "comprise a total geographic inventory of the West which would have meaning and utility for Westbound Americans, whatever their needs."[52] Materials were collected and brought "back East" to be classified and organized in order to chart a "Linnaean cosmic order."[53]

This inventory functions in part to contain the previously unknown and unpredictable, to mark out the perimeter of what is possible. The

physical removal of specimens for classification further implies a process of containment and abstraction. Such a practice is at odds with McCarthy's sense of a kind of deep political ecology, and the assessment made of science by someone like T. E. Hulme would not be out of place in *Blood Meridian*. "The aim of science and all of thought," writes Hulme, "is to reduce the complex and inevitably disconnected world of grit and cinders to a few ideal counters which we can move about and so form an ungritlike picture of reality—one flattering to our sense of power over the world." Unity is made in the world, according to Hulme, "by drawing squares over it" in the manner of a "sorting machine."[54] The idea that the order charted upon this map contains everything is, however, a fiction of rational unity. Not only can the representation not grasp and fully contain that which it describes, but things are deliberately left out.

What is left out of the ordering of space in the aftermath of territorial wars is the granulated remains of the exterminated, turned into landscape by the violence left unchecked by an expansionist politics that articulates itself as a force of nature. The ostensible "thereness" of land as outside human history and the notionally primordial depravity of unregulated human beings in their "natural" state are made to work, in fact, as the legitimizing agents of the process of domination that renders them finally as waste. "Nature" and its human counterparts are thereby consumed and excluded even as their excessive otherness is reinvested as the necessary sacrificial component of the orderly state. This process is by no means completed with the consolidation and mapping of territorial limits that concludes *Blood Meridian*. Rather, as I argue in the following chapters, the delimiting of Western space as "wasteland" is a necessary precondition upon which can be built a national order based on the perpetual sacrifice of its abjected waste.

2. The Prehistory of the Permanent War Economy

1. Jay Ellis has dismissed the notion that McCarthy's scalp hunters are "the gleaming white bad guys of revisionist history," pointing out that they "are hardly all white (whatever that is)" and that "they kill anyone they please, for a variety of reasons that are only provisionally connected to anything so ephemeral or quotidian as a local political agenda." See Jay Ellis, *No Place for Home: Spatial Constraint and Character Flight in the Novels of Cormac McCarthy* (New York: Routledge, 2006), 176, 175. My argument in this chapter is that it is precisely the feral and non-instrumental nature of the violence performed by the scalp hunters that

underwrites it as an action constitutive of state formation. The very construal of violence as mythic or primal serves to externalize and dehistoricize acts of violent conquest as outside political legitimacy even as the state is called into being by such violence. In short, the members of Glanton's gang do not need to be white nor do they have to know what they are doing. The fact that they appear to be operating outside of any historical imperative is a condition of their historical efficacy. The pursuit of unreflective libidinal violence does not have to have a reason in order to have an effect. The agents of Manifest Destiny are not required to be conscious of their actions as politically effective—any more than military service personnel are required to have a view as to the political legitimacy of their duties—so long as the results do indeed achieve that destiny. In fact, Ellis later comes to much the same conclusion when he writes that the Glanton gang is "beyond the pale of civil authority even as they enact that authority," reminding us that "ignorance on the part of the gang as to their violent function does not alter the function itself " (191). The utilization, official or otherwise, of expendable human resources in the furtherance of political aims is hardly invented by nineteenth century U.S. expansionism, but it would be mistaken to assume that legitimate force is the only means at the state's disposal.

2. Hardt and Negri, *Multitude*, 7.

3. Hardt and Negri, *Multitude*, 37.

4. In a revealing discussion, Ellis has perspicuously noted how *Blood Meridian* "describes a shift in time" from "antinomian space" to "historical place" (*No Place for Home*, 170).

5. Cormac McCarthy, *Blood Meridian, or, The Evening Redness in the West* (London: Picador, 1985), 50. Further references are cited in the text with the abbreviation BM.

6. For an extensive discussion on the historical sources of the novel, see John Sepich, *Notes on Blood Meridian* (Louisville KY: Bellarmine College Press, 1993).

7. Dana Phillips, "History and the Ugly Facts of *Blood Meridian*," in *Cormac McCarthy: New Directions*, ed. James D. Lilley (Albuquerque: University of New Mexico Press, 2002), 38.

8. Thomas Pughe, "Revision and Vision: Cormac McCarthy's *Blood Meridian*," *Revue française d'études americaines* 62 (November 1994): 381.

9. Phillips, "History and the Ugly Facts," 38.

10. Richard Godden and Colin Richmond, "'Blood Meridian', or the Evening Redness in the East: 'Itinerant Degenerates Bleeding Westwards,'" *Comparative American Studies* 2, no. 4 (2004): 448.

11. Phillips, "History and the Ugly Facts," 23.

12. Vereen Bell, *The Achievement of Cormac McCarthy* (Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press 1988), 132. Phillips argues that McCarthy's similes "seem designed to increase the intensity and accuracy of focus on the objects being

described rather than to suggest that they have double natures or bear hidden meanings" (Phillips, "History and the Ugly Facts," 36).

13. Susan Kollin, "Genre and Geographies of Violence: Cormac McCarthy and the Contemporary Western," *Contemporary Literature* 42, no. 3 (2001): 562.

14. I am not saying that Kollin is necessarily redeeming *Blood Meridian* in this way, but in setting oppositions between the Western's conventional tropes and McCarthy's refusal of them, the way is cleared for such an unproblematic revisionist reading of the novel.

15. Kollin, "Genre and Geographies of Violence." 561. For a discussion of the Western's "self-subverting" tendency, see Forrest G. Robinson, *Having It Both Ways: Self-Subversion in Western Popular Classics* (Albuquerque: University of New Mexico Press, 1993).

16. Peter Josyph, "Blood Music: Reading *Blood Meridian*," in *Sacred Violence: A Reader's Companion to Cormac McCarthy*, ed. Wade Hall and Rick Wallach (El Paso: Texas Western Press, 1995), 186; Steven Shaviro, "'The Very Life of Darkness': A Reading of *Blood Meridian*," in *Perspectives on Cormac McCarthy*, ed. Edwin T. Arnold and Dianne Luce, 2nd ed. (Jackson: University of Mississippi Press, 1999), 152.

17. Shaviro, "'The Very Life of Darkness,'" 147.

18. Shaviro, "'The Very Life of Darkness,'" 147.

19. David Holloway, *The Late Modernism of Cormac McCarthy* (Westport CT: Greenwood, 2002), 16.

20. Holloway, *Late Modernism*, 44.

21. Frederic Jameson, *The Seeds of Time* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1994), 1, 52, quoted in Holloway, *Late Modernism*, 54.

22. For studies that position *Blood Meridian* as a novel with things to say about Vietnam, see Vince Brewton, "The Changing Landscape of Violence in Cormac McCarthy's Early Novels and the Border Trilogy," *Southern Literary Journal* 37, no. 1 (2004): 121–43; Godden and Richmond, "Blood Meridian."

23. Godden and Richmond, "Blood Meridian," 449.

24. Holloway, *Late Modernism*, 47.

25. Godden and Richmond, "Blood Meridian," 451.

26. Godden and Richmond, "Blood Meridian," 452.

27. John C. Van Dyke, *The Desert: Further Studies in Natural Appearances* (London: Sampson Low, Marston, 1901), 200.

28. Van Dyke, *The Desert*, 26–27.

29. Van Dyke, *The Desert*, 27.

30. The first use of the word "prehistory" in English, according to Alice Beck Kehoe, was in Daniel Wilson's *The Archaeology and Prehistoric Annals of Scotland* (1851). See Alice Beck Kehoe, *The Land of Prehistory: A Critical History of American Archaeology* (New York: Routledge, 1998) xiii.

31. Kehoe, *The Land of Prehistory*, xiii.

32. Kehoe, *The Land of Prehistory*, xi.

33. Kehoe, *The Land of Prehistory*, 40.

34. On degeneration theory, see Gregory Moore, *Nietzsche, Biology and Metaphor* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2002), 117: "Theories of descent not only suggested that human and ape shared a common ancestor; they implied a hierarchy leading from the simian primogenitor, through primitive peoples to civilized Europeans. At the same time, the concept of *dégénérescence* served to characterize other races as degenerate deviations from the ideal white type. These purportedly inferior races could be identified by atavistic skull and brain sizes which revealed their more immediate relation to the ape than those races at a more 'advanced' stage of cultural development. Racial biology, in other words, became a science of boundaries between groups; when these boundaries were transgressed, degeneration threatened. New anxieties about the proper place of different classes, nationalities and ethnicities, as well as the sexes, in society allowed racial biology to become a model for the analysis of the distances that were supposedly 'natural' between the various peoples." Among the many examples of this kind of racial thinking in *Blood Meridian*, the judge's argument that "you can't be all Mexican. It's like being all mongrel" is typical (159).

35. Godden and Richmond, "Blood Meridian," 451.

36. Godden and Richmond, "Blood Meridian," 451.

37. Ellis makes a similar point when he notes how the kid's discovery of dead babies hanging from a tree is repeated in *All the Pretty Horses* when John Grady finds birds impaled by the wind on the thorns of a cholla cactus: "From babies to birds: the violence is still there, but stepped down several levels" (*No Place for Home*, 180).

38. *Blood Meridian*'s heliocentrism invokes the age-old belief in the heliotropic myth that imagines history as a succession of civilizations moving, like the sun, from East to West. In many versions of the myth, America is often conceived as the last empire. For a thorough cultural history of the heliotropic myth, see Jan Willem Schulte Nordholt, *The Myth of the West: America As the Last Empire*, trans. Herbert H. Rowen (Grand Rapids MI: Eerdmans, 1995). I am grateful to William Handley for drawing my attention to this book.

39. Georges Bataille, "Rotten Sun," in *Visions of Excess: Selected Writings, 1927–1939*, ed. Allan Stoekl, trans. Allan Stoekl, Carl R. Lovitt, and Donald M. Leslie Jr. (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1985), 57–58. See also T. E. Hulme, "Cinders," in *Selected Writings*, ed. Patrick McGuinness (Manchester: Carcanet, 1998), 24: "The eyes, the beauty of the world, have been organised out of the faeces. Man returns to dust. So does the face of the world to primeval cinders."

40. See Shaviro, "'The Very Life of Darkness,'" 147: "Zenith and horizon continually exchange places, without mediation or delay; what is most dim, distant and uncertain abruptly appears as an inescapable fatality." See also Neil Campbell, "Liberty Beyond Its Proper Bounds: Cormac McCarthy's History of the West in *Blood Meridian*," in *Myth, Legend, Dust: Critical Responses to Cormac McCarthy*, ed.

Rick Wallach (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2000), 221: "*Blood Meridian* is the point at which one reaches the climax of life and simultaneously recognizes the proximity, even the inevitability of its end."

41. Ellis discusses the title of the novel at length. See *No Place for Home*, 188–91.

42. See Ellis, *No Place for Home*, 188–89: "The book's secondary title is 'The Evening Redness in the West.' Numerous references to 'blood' indicate that redness, and we may remember that our perception of a single color is in itself a trick of the perceiver's selective perception of the full spectrum of light. The second title, then, points again backwards. Rather than providing us with a reliable reference point (a meridian, the sun), against which we might measure the actions of the book, we are instead thrown back on a realization that all we can do is to perceive, and in perceiving, we see something that is not objectively true."

43. See Ellis, *No Place for Home*, 191: The Glanton gang "cross the meridian of blood between lawless killing and the legal, civilized, near-holocaust carried out not only by the United States, but also by the local Mexican government, by creating a trade in dead human beings."

44. James D. Lilley refers to McCarthy's rendering of the "horizontal, physical, factualness of things." See "Representing Cormac McCarthy's 'Desert Absolute': Edward Weston, Ansel Adams, and the Dynamics of Vision," *Proceedings of the Second International Conference on the Emerging Literature of the Southwest*, September 13–15, 1996, El Paso, Texas (El Paso: University of Texas at El Paso, 1996), 163. For extended discussion of optical democracy, see for example, Phillips, "History and the Ugly Facts," 30, 37: "The suggested independence of light and dark reinforces the lack of precedence, of referential order, in the natural world." The book's "odd power derives from its treating everything and everybody with absolute equanimity." See also Holloway, *Late Modernism*, 135: "the style of 'optical democracy' connotes a writing that renders all preference among objects 'whimsical' (moral preference, epistemological preference, aesthetic or political preference), until anything beyond the uniform facticity of the moment is crowded out from view."

45. Georges Bataille, *The Accursed Share*, trans. Robert Hurley (1967; New York: Zone, 1991), 1:58; emphasis in original.

46. Bataille, *Accursed Share*, 1:52–53.

47. See Ellis, *No Place for Home*, 188–91.

48. The most commonly held interpretation is that the actions described in the epilogue are those of a posthole digger, signifying the fencing off of the West. Harold Bloom prefers a Promethean reading and refuses the Western allegorical view of the end of the novel. Ellis's argument for a combination of the historical and mythic interpretations seems, as my own claims here for a folding of the prehistoric into historical time would suggest, the most appropriate way of approaching the epilogue. See Peter Josyph, "Tragic Ecstasy: A Conversation with

Harold Bloom about Cormac McCarthy's *Blood Meridian*," *Southwestern American Literature* 26, no. 1 (2000): 14–15; Ellis, *No Place for Home*, 192–98.

49. Holloway, *Late Modernism*, 171. See also Harold Bloom, *How to Read and Why* (New York: Scribner, 2001). Bloom concurs that the novel does not allow Holden "the last word" (262–63). Similarly, for Godden and Richmond the epilogue reveals the judge's belief that he will never die as "delusional" (458).

50. Phillips, "History and the Ugly Facts," 40.

51. Ellis, *No Place for Home*, 171. Ellis does valuable historical work locating the practice described in the epilogue within the context of the surveying and fencing of the West. See especially 194–97.

52. William H. Goetzmann, *Exploration and Empire: The Explorer and the Scientist in the Winning of the American West* (Austin: Texas State Historical Association, 2000), 303.

53. Goetzmann, *Exploration and Empire*, 305.

54. Hulme, "Cinders," 22.